

SOP-INV-2300: Incident Investigation and Root Cause Analysis

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Section 1. Purpose and Scope

Governs investigation of incidents, near-misses, and process safety events, and the corrective action tracking that follows.

Section 2. Classification and Response Time

Clause 2.1 — A recordable injury, a process safety Tier 1 or Tier 2 event, or any incident with significant loss-prevention potential requires a formal investigation initiated within 24 hours.

Clause 2.2 — A near-miss with high potential severity is investigated with the same rigor as an actual incident of that severity — investigation depth is set by potential consequence, not actual outcome.

Section 3. Investigation Team

Clause 3.1 — The investigation team shall include at minimum the area supervisor, a safety representative, and, for process safety events, a process engineer; the investigation shall not be conducted solely by the supervisor of the personnel involved.

Section 4. Root Cause Method

Clause 4.1 — Root cause analysis shall identify underlying systemic causes (procedure gaps, training gaps, equipment design), not stop at the immediate/proximate cause (e.g., “employee error”) — a finding of employee error alone is not an acceptable investigation conclusion without addressing why the system allowed that error to occur or to result in harm.

Section 5. Corrective Actions

Clause 5.1 — Every finding requires an assigned corrective action with an owner and due date; corrective actions addressing systemic causes take priority over actions that only address the specific incident.

Clause 5.2 — Corrective action completion is verified by someone other than the assigned owner before the investigation is closed.

Section 6. Records

Clause 6.1 — Investigation reports and corrective action tracking are filed to the Safety Department File and retained for 10 years.